



“Who are you and why are you here?” boomed the giant Polyphemus.

Odysseus was a cunning man, and he had his answer ready. “My name is Nobody and these are my men,” he said. “We hoped you would share your home with us for the night.”

At these words, the Cyclops sneered. He swiped up two of Odysseus’s men from the ground and ate them whole. The rest of the men screamed in horror, but Odysseus stayed calm and watched as Polyphemus lay down and went to sleep.

In the morning, the Cyclops left with his sheep, but kept the men trapped in the cave. The next night, the grisly process was repeated, with another two of Odysseus’s men becoming the monster’s dinner.

This time Odysseus had a plan.

“Would you like some wine to wash down your meal?” Odysseus asked, offering the Cyclops a bottle he had brought from the ship. Polyphemus greedily drank the entire bottle in one gulp. What he didn’t know was that the wine was very, very strong—it was meant to be mixed with lots of water to dilute it. The effects of the drink were instant. Polyphemus swayed on the spot, then collapsed to the floor.

With the Cyclops impossible to wake, Odysseus ordered the crew to sharpen a long branch he had found in the cave. When it was sharp and spiked, they heaved it onto their shoulders and rammed it into the sleeping giant’s eye.



Polyphemus drank the bottle of wine all at once.